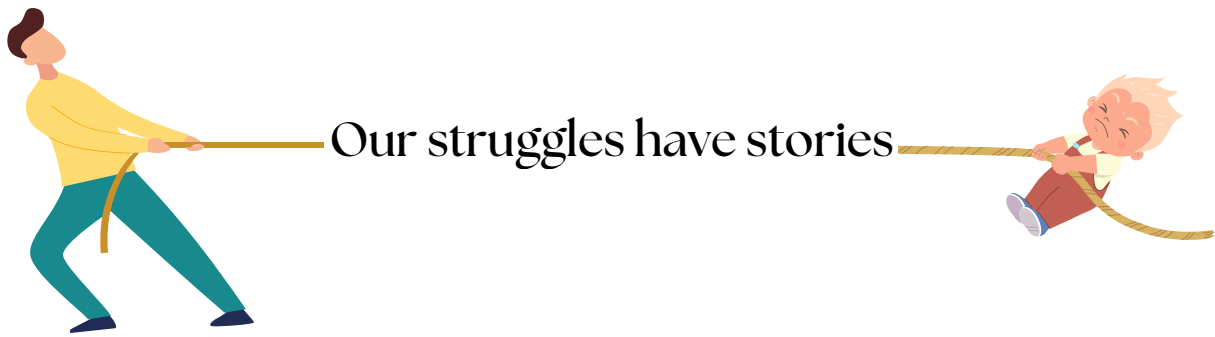




The struggles we face as adults often have roots in childhood adaptations. These adaptations or strategies were critical to minimize threats and ensure survival, especially in environments where parts of ourselves were criticized or rejected by parents. If making mistakes lead to harsh parental criticism, you may have adopted a "perfectionistic" strategy to regain positive attention (ie..g, love) from your caregiver. As children, we develop "protector" parts to shield the parts of us—referred to as "exiles"—that were seen as unacceptable. This echoes Internal Family Systems (IFS) therapy, which explains that individuals develop internal systems with parts that protect the self from being overwhelmed by painful emotions.

Without conscious awareness, adults can re-enact patterns from their own upbringing. The way we were parented can shape how we unconsciously interact with our children or partners. For example, we may inadvertently attempt to shut down traits in our children that were rejected in us, perpetuating cycles of emotional suppression.

Writing exercise:

Write down on a piece of paper...

"I struggle with the _____ part of me. This struggle has a story."



Protectors

As adults, we may have "protector" parts whose jobs are to guard against the emotional pain or vulnerabilities formed in childhood. These protectors help us avoid feelings that were too painful to address when we were younger, but they may not always serve us or our loved ones in healthy ways. Here are some common examples of protector roles or behaviors that adults may adopt:

- 1.) The Perfectionist
- 2.) Overprotective Sibling
- 3.) The Dismissive Partner
- 4.) The Authoritarian Parent
- 5.) The Workaholic Employee



Exiles

We also have wounded aspects of ourselves that were often repressed or pushed away during childhood due to experiences of pain, shame, or fear. These parts hold emotions, desires, or traits that were unacceptable in our early environments. These parts hold painful memories and unresolved feelings and are often "exiled" by protector parts to avoid discomfort or emotional overwhelm.

1. The Not-Good-Enough Child
2. The Helpless Child
3. The Sensitive Child
4. The Fearful Child
5. The Unloved Child

